Class 9 History – Chapter 4

Early Humans and Beginning of Civilisation

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Purpose: These notes are designed not merely for revision, but for classroom explanation. The chapter is arranged as a continuous story: **human evolution → hunter-gatherers → stone tools → farming → settled life → villages → metals → cities → early civilisations → interaction and trade.**

NCERT alignment: The official Grade 9 syllabus places this chapter under History and includes cultural development from about 2 million years ago, archaeological ages, human ancestors, Palaeolithic/Mesolithic/Neolithic developments, the Harappan and contemporary cultures, and the Mesopotamian, Egyptian and Chinese civilisations. ■cite■turn2search10■

1. The Big Picture – Start the Chapter Like a Story

Ask students: **"If there were no houses, farms, shops, roads, schools or writing, how would human beings survive?"** Explain that for most of human history, people lived without cities and writing. They depended directly on nature, gradually developed tools and knowledge, learned to use fire, and later began producing food. That change eventually created permanent settlements, specialised occupations, trade, social organisation and cities.

Human story in one flow

EARLY HUMANS → TOOL-MAKING → FIRE → HUNTER-GATHERING → MIGRATION → CAVE/ROCK-SHELTER LIFE → AGRICULTURE & DOMESTICATION → PERMANENT SETTLEMENTS → VILLAGES → SURPLUS → CRAFT SPECIALISATION & TRADE → METALLURGY → TOWNS/CITIES → WRITING & ADMINISTRATION → CIVILISATIONS

Key idea: Civilisation was not created suddenly by one invention. It was the result of many gradual changes interacting with one another.

2. How Do We Know About the Earliest Humans?

Archaeology is the study of past human life through material remains. For periods before writing, historians rely heavily on archaeological evidence.

Evidence	What it can tell us
Fossils / human remains	Body structure, physical evolution, approximate age and health.
Stone and bone tools	Technology, activities such as cutting, hunting and processing food.
Animal bones	Diet, hunting practices and sometimes domestication.
Seeds, grains and plant remains	Food habits and the beginnings of agriculture.
Pottery and storage vessels	Food storage, cooking, craft and settled life.
Houses, streets, drains and buildings	Settlement planning and urban organisation.
Burials and ornaments	Possible beliefs, social practices and cultural behaviour.
Rock/cave paintings and engravings	Art, symbolic expression and aspects of daily life.

Important distinction: Prehistory refers broadly to periods for which written records are absent; protohistory is commonly used for cultures known through archaeology and/or references in other cultures but whose own writing is not fully understood. History in the narrower sense becomes much easier to reconstruct once written records are available.

3. Human Evolution – Who Were Our Ancestors?

Human evolution was a long process of biological and cultural change. The chapter uses fossils, tools and other archaeological evidence to understand earlier members of the human family. Avoid teaching evolution as a simple straight ladder: different human species existed at different times, and some overlapped.

Name	Broad significance for teaching
Australopithecus	Early human relative associated with upright walking; lived in Africa.
Homo habilis	Associated with early stone-tool traditions; brain and body characteristics differed from later Homo.
Homo erectus	More human-like body proportions; spread widely beyond Africa; associated with sophisticated tool use and use/control of fire in some contexts.
Homo neanderthalensis	Lived mainly in Europe and parts of western Asia; adapted to cold environments and had complex behaviours.
Homo sapiens	Our species; developed highly complex technologies, symbolic expression, language and culture and eventually spread worldwide.

Teacher explanation: “Biological evolution” means changes in bodies and inherited characteristics over generations. “Cultural evolution” means changes in learned behaviour, technology, language, knowledge and social practices. Human success depended on both.

Skull trend to remember: earlier forms generally show more projecting faces and stronger brow regions; over the long evolutionary sequence, the human face becomes more vertical and the braincase becomes more prominent.

4. Periodisation of Early Human History

Historians and archaeologists divide the long prehistoric past into periods using broad patterns of technology and livelihood. These labels are useful, but the dates were not identical everywhere.

Period	Meaning / main basis	Main features
Palaeolithic	Old Stone Age	Hunter-gatherers; chipped/flaked stone tools; mobility; caves/rock shelters and temporary camps; control/use of fire.
Mesolithic	Middle Stone Age	Microliths; more varied hunting, fishing and gathering; greater use of local resources; transition toward food production in some regions.
Neolithic	New Stone Age	Agriculture; domestication; permanent villages; polished stone tools; pottery and weaving in many communities.
Chalcolithic	Copper-Stone Age	Copper used alongside stone; expanding craft production and exchange; occurs at different times in different regions.
Bronze Age	Age of bronze metallurgy	Bronze tools/weapons; urban growth; long-distance trade; early states/civilisations in several regions.
Iron Age	Widespread iron use	Iron tools and weapons; technological and social changes; larger and more complex societies in many regions.

Flow to put on the board: Stone technology → improved tools → food-processing/hunting efficiency → farming → metalworking → larger settlements → cities and complex societies.

5. Palaeolithic Life – Hunter-Gatherers

Palaeolithic people were primarily **hunter-gatherers**: they hunted animals and collected naturally available foods such as fruits, roots, nuts, seeds and other plant resources. They did not depend on farming for their main food supply.

Feature	Palaeolithic pattern
Food	Hunting + gathering; food depended strongly on local environment.
Settlement	Generally mobile or semi-mobile; temporary camps, caves and rock shelters.
Tools	Stone tools such as handaxes, cleavers, scrapers, choppers and points.
Fire	Provided warmth, light, protection and helped process/cook food.
Social life	Small groups requiring cooperation and sharing of knowledge.
Communication	Speech, gestures, signs and symbolic expression developed over long periods.
Art / symbolism	Cave and rock art, engravings, ornaments and body decoration in some communities.

Why mobility? If food resources moved or became scarce, groups needed to move. Therefore, mobility was an adaptation to a hunter-gatherer economy, not simply a sign of “primitive” life.

6. Stone Tools – Why Were They So Important?

Stone was durable and could be shaped to produce sharp edges. Tool-making expanded the range of activities humans could perform.

Tool type / form	Possible use
Handaxe	Cutting, chopping and processing materials.
Cleaver	Heavy cutting/chopping.
Scraper	Working hides/skins and other materials.
Point	Hunting and piercing.
Microlith	Small sharp stone tool, often set into wood/bone to form composite tools.
Polished axe	Cutting wood and clearing vegetation, especially in farming communities.
Sickle blade	Harvesting crops; commonly associated with food production.

Remember: A tool is evidence of technology, but archaeologists must combine several kinds of evidence before concluding exactly how it was used.

7. Mesolithic – A Transitional Phase

The Mesolithic is often described as a bridge between the Palaeolithic and Neolithic, but it was not identical everywhere. Communities continued hunting and gathering while, in some places, moving toward more intensive use and management of plants and animals.

Palaeolithic → Mesolithic change	What it means
Large tools → microliths	Smaller stone tools could be fitted into handles or shafts.
Broad-spectrum food gathering	Greater use of fish, small animals, birds, shellfish and plant resources in suitable environments.
Seasonal/local settlement	Some groups stayed longer in resource-rich locations.
Transition toward food production	In certain regions, experimentation with cultivation and domestication gradually developed.

8. Neolithic Revolution – The Great Turning Point

The **Neolithic Revolution** refers to the major transformation from predominantly hunting-gathering toward food production through agriculture and animal domestication, accompanied by settled village life. “Revolution” is used because its consequences were enormous, even though the change itself happened gradually and at different times in different regions.

Why did farming begin?

Climate and environmental changes after the last Ice Age, knowledge accumulated by hunter-gatherers, availability of wild grains and animals, population pressures and experimentation all contributed in different places. There was no single cause or one universal date.

The chain of change

Observation of plants/animals → selective cultivation & management → domestication → reliable food production → surplus in good years → storage → permanent/seasonal settlements → population growth → craft specialisation → exchange/trade → larger settlements → social and political organisation

Domestication: the process by which humans gradually changed plants and animals through sustained management and selective breeding, making them more useful and dependent on human care.

9. Palaeolithic vs Mesolithic vs Neolithic

Feature	Palaeolithic	Mesolithic	Neolithic
Food	Hunting & gathering	Hunting, fishing, gathering; intensive local resources	Farming + domesticated animals + continued gathering/hunting

Feature	Palaeolithic	Mesolithic	Neolithic
Tools	Flaked/chipped stone tools	Microliths and varied tools	Polished stone tools; sickles/axes in many regions
Settlement	Mobile/temporary	Often seasonal or semi-settled in some regions	Permanent villages increasingly common
Animals	Wild animals hunted	Hunting; early management in some regions	Domestication becomes important
Plants	Wild plants gathered	Greater use/management of plant resources	Cultivated crops
Pottery	Limited/region-specific	Region-specific	Common in many Neolithic communities
Major historical change	Adaptation to nature	Transition and experimentation	Food production and settled life

10. From Village to Civilisation

Once people produced food, some communities could generate and store **surplus**. Surplus did not automatically create civilisation, but it made new possibilities easier: some people could specialise in crafts, trade, administration, construction or religious roles rather than producing food full-time.

Village → surplus → craft specialists → exchange → growing population → larger settlements → social differentiation → organised leadership/administration → cities → states/civilisations

Concept	Simple meaning
Surplus	Production beyond immediate consumption, allowing storage or exchange.
Division of labour	Different people specialise in different occupations.
Specialisation	Development of skilled occupations such as pottery, weaving, metalworking or trade.
Urbanisation	Growth of towns/cities with dense populations and specialised activities.
State	Organised political authority over a territory and population.
Civilisation	A complex society generally characterised by cities, organised political/social institutions, specialised work, trade, technological development and cultural/religious systems.

11. Metals and the Archaeological Ages

Metalworking changed tools, weapons and crafts. **Copper** was one of the earliest widely used metals; **bronze** is an alloy mainly of copper and tin; later, iron became increasingly important because of its properties and availability in many regions.

Material	Why important?
Stone	Earliest major tool material; easy to find and shape in many regions.
Copper	Malleable metal; could be hammered and shaped; eventually smelted.
Bronze	Harder than pure copper; useful for tools and weapons; metallurgy encouraged specialised craft production and trade.
Iron	Strong and widely available in many regions; iron technology supported new tools and weapons and affected agriculture and warfare.

12. Why Did Early Civilisations Grow Near Rivers?

Major early civilisations developed in environments with reliable water and fertile agricultural land. Rivers were not the only reason, but they provided important advantages.

River	Civilisation / region	Key environmental role
Indus and associated river systems	Sindhu–Sarasvat■ / Harappan civilisation	Water, agriculture, transport and links across settlements.
Tigris & Euphrates	Mesopotamia	Irrigation agriculture, transport and fertile alluvial plains.

River	Civilisation / region	Key environmental role
Nile	Egypt	Water, fertile floodplain, transport and a strong geographic corridor.
Huang He / Yellow River	Early Chinese civilisation	Water and fertile loess regions supporting agriculture and settlement.

But rivers also brought risks: floods, droughts, changing river channels and water-management problems. Early societies had to develop irrigation, drainage, storage and other techniques.

13. The Four Major Bronze Age Civilisations in the Chapter

Civilisation	Approx. region	River system / setting	Major features to teach
Sindhu–Sarasvat■ / Harappan	Northwestern South Asia and adjoining regions	Indus and related river systems	Planned cities, drainage, standardised weights, craft production, seals, long-distance trade; script remains undeciphered.
Mesopotamian	Modern Iraq and adjoining Southwest Asia	Tigris–Euphrates	City-states, irrigation, temples, cuneiform writing, trade, specialised crafts and complex administration.
Egyptian	Northeastern Africa	Nile	Pharaohs/kingship, temples, pyramids/monuments, hieroglyphic writing, agriculture and an organised social structure.
Chinese	Northern China and expanding regions	Huang He and other river systems	Agriculture, bronze traditions, early states/dynasties, writing and distinctive craft traditions.

Common pattern: river/environmental resources + agriculture + surplus + specialised crafts + trade + organised authority + religious institutions + writing/record-keeping → complex urban society.

14. Sindhu–Sarasvat■ / Harappan Civilisation

This civilisation is known from a wide archaeological distribution across parts of present-day India and Pakistan. Important urban centres include **Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira and Rakhigarhi**. The civilisation is especially notable for planned settlements and standardisation.

Feature	What students should understand
Urban planning	Many settlements show planned streets, buildings and carefully organised spaces.
Drainage	Mohenjo-daro and other sites show sophisticated drainage and water-management arrangements.
Crafts	Beads, pottery, metal objects, shell work and other specialised crafts.
Weights & measures	Standardised weights suggest organised exchange and economic regulation.
Seals	Often depict animals and symbols; probably connected with identity, trade or administration.
Trade	Evidence indicates exchange within the civilisation and with distant regions, including Mesopotamia.
Writing	Harappan signs occur on seals and objects, but the script has not been securely deciphered.
Political structure	The exact form of government is still debated; archaeology does not allow us to name rulers with certainty.

Important caution for students: Do not say “we know the Harappan king was ___.” The script is undeciphered and the political system is not fully understood.

15. Mesopotamian Civilisation

“Mesopotamia” means the land between rivers, referring to the Tigris and Euphrates. It developed in a fertile but environmentally challenging region where irrigation was important.

Topic	Mesopotamia
Cities	Uruk and other city-states became major urban centres.
Political organisation	City-states and later larger kingdoms/empires developed.

Topic	Mesopotamia
Writing	Cuneiform was written by pressing a stylus into clay tablets.
Economy	Agriculture, irrigation, crafts and trade.
Religion	Polytheistic religious traditions; temples and priests had important roles.
Law/administration	Written records helped manage taxes, trade, property and administration; later law codes became important.
Trade	Connected Mesopotamia with surrounding regions for metals, timber, stones and other resources.

16. Ancient Egyptian Civilisation

Egypt grew along the Nile. The predictable rhythm of the river and fertile floodplain supported agriculture, while the river also served as a transport route.

Topic	Egypt
Political system	Pharaoh-centred kingship; strong central authority developed at various times.
Religion	Polytheistic traditions; strong beliefs concerning gods, death and the afterlife.
Writing	Hieroglyphic writing used on monuments and other surfaces; other scripts were also used for practical writing.
Architecture	Pyramids, temples, tombs and other monumental structures.
Economy	Agriculture, crafts, trade and taxation/redistribution.
Society	Hierarchical structure including rulers, officials, priests, soldiers, artisans, farmers and labourers.

17. Early Chinese Civilisation

Early Chinese civilisation developed in northern China, especially around the Huang He and nearby regions. Agriculture, bronze working, writing and organised political authority became important features.

Topic	Early China
Environment	River valleys and fertile loess soils supported agriculture.
Political organisation	Early states and dynastic traditions developed.
Bronze	Highly skilled bronze casting became an important craft tradition.
Writing	Early Chinese writing is associated with inscriptions, including oracle-bone inscriptions.
Society	Hierarchical political and social organisation developed alongside expanding states.
Cultural legacy	Writing, bronze technology and political traditions had long-lasting influence.

18. Compare the Four Civilisations

Basis	Sindhu–Sarasvat■	Mesopotamia	Egypt	China
Main river setting	Indus & associated systems	Tigris–Euphrates	Nile	Huang He
Urban planning	Highly standardised in many cities	Major cities/city-states	Cities, temples and administrative centres	Urban/state centres developed over time
Writing	Script undeciphered	Cuneiform	Hieroglyphic + other scripts	Early Chinese script
Metallurgy	Copper/bronze traditions	Bronze important	Copper/bronze traditions	Advanced bronze casting
Religion	Evidence from archaeology; interpretation debated	Polytheistic temple traditions	Polytheistic; strong afterlife beliefs	Ancestor and deity traditions in early periods
Distinctive examples	Drainage, weights, seals	Cuneiform, city-states, irrigation	Pyramids, Nile, pharaohs	Oracle bones, bronze casting

19. Similarities and Differences – High-Value Exam Table

Similarities	Differences
All relied heavily on agriculture.	Different rivers and ecological conditions shaped each society.
Surplus supported specialised occupations.	Political structures were not identical.
Craft production and trade developed.	Writing systems were different; Harappan script remains undeciphered.
Religion and ritual were important.	Architecture and artistic traditions differed.
Organised settlements and administration emerged.	The degree and form of centralisation varied.
Long-distance exchange connected regions.	Each civilisation had its own local resources, technologies and cultural practices.

20. How Did Early Civilisations Interact?

Civilisations were not isolated. People moved, traded, migrated and exchanged ideas. Archaeologists identify contact through objects, materials, styles and written references.

Local production → surplus → merchants/traders → routes by land/river/sea → exchange of metals, stones, timber, shells, textiles and other goods → cultural contact → diffusion of ideas/technologies

Example: Archaeological and textual evidence points to contacts between the Harappan world and Mesopotamia. Trade required knowledge of routes, weights, commodities and trusted exchange systems.

21. Before Writing vs After Writing

Before widespread writing	After writing
Mainly archaeological evidence	Archaeological + written evidence
Tools, fossils, bones, structures, art	Documents can provide names, dates, laws, accounts and narratives
Dating often approximate	Some events can be dated more precisely when records provide dates
Thoughts and institutions are harder to reconstruct	Language, administration, laws and political events become more directly accessible
Interpretation is especially dependent on material evidence	Written evidence still needs critical interpretation and may reflect the viewpoint of its author

22. Important Terms – Student-Friendly Glossary

Term	Meaning
Archaeology	Study of past human life through material remains.
Artefact	An object made or modified by humans.
Fossil	Preserved remains or traces of ancient life.
Hunter-gatherer	Person/community obtaining food mainly by hunting, fishing and gathering wild resources.
Domestication	Long-term process of managing and selectively breeding plants/animals so they become adapted to human use.
Agriculture	Cultivation of crops and related food-producing activities.
Surplus	Extra production beyond immediate needs.
Metallurgy	Knowledge and technology of obtaining and working metals.
Bronze	Alloy mainly of copper and tin.
Civilisation	Complex society with urban centres and developed economic, social, political and cultural institutions.
Cuneiform	Wedge-shaped writing system used in ancient Mesopotamia.

Term	Meaning
Hieroglyphs	A system of picture-based signs used in ancient Egypt.
Microlith	Very small stone tool, often used as part of a composite tool.
Neolithic Revolution	Major transition toward farming, domestication and settled life.

23. Classroom Explanation Flow – 9-Hour Chapter Plan

Hour	Focus	Classroom flow
1	Human origins & evidence	Ask the opening question → archaeology → fossils/tools → prehistory.
2	Human ancestors	Australopithecus → Homo habilis → Homo erectus → Neanderthals → Homo sapiens; biological vs cultural evolution.
3	Palaeolithic	Hunter-gatherers → tools → fire → mobility → art/symbolism.
4	Mesolithic & Neolithic	Microliths → environmental change → experimentation → farming/domestication.
5	Neolithic Revolution	Cause → process → effects → village life; compare Palaeolithic/Mesolithic/Neolithic.
6	From villages to civilisation	Surplus → division of labour → trade → metals → towns/cities.
7	River-valley civilisations	Why rivers? Four civilisations overview and map activity.
8	Civilisations in detail	Harappan → Mesopotamian → Egyptian → Chinese; comparison table.
9	Interaction & revision	Trade/contact → writing → key terms → comparison → oral recap/worksheet.

24. Quick Blackboard Flow Chart

EARLY HUMANS
↓
Hunter-Gatherers + Stone Tools + Fire
↓
Palaeolithic
↓
Mesolithic: Microliths + Transition
↓
Neolithic Revolution
↓
Farming + Animal Domestication
↓
Permanent Villages + Surplus
↓
Craft Specialisation + Trade
↓
Copper → Bronze → Iron
↓
Towns & Cities
↓
Writing + Administration + Social Organisation
↓
EARLY CIVILISATIONS
Sindhu–Sarasvat■ | Mesopotamia | Egypt | China

25. Common Student Confusions – Correct Them Immediately

Confusion	Correct explanation
“Palaeolithic people were stupid.”	No. They had sophisticated environmental knowledge, tool-making skills, cooperation and symbolic behaviour.
“Neolithic means everyone started farming at the same time.”	No. Farming began independently/gradually in different regions at different times.
“Civilisation means only buildings.”	No. It includes complex economic, political, social and cultural organisation.
“All river civilisations had the same government.”	No. They shared broad patterns but had different political institutions.
“Harappan script has been translated.”	No. It remains undeciphered.
“Bronze is a pure metal.”	No. Bronze is an alloy, mainly of copper and tin.
“Agriculture immediately created cities.”	No. There were long transitions from farming villages to urban societies.
“Archaeology gives exact answers to everything.”	No. Archaeological evidence must be interpreted, and many questions remain debated.

26. Five Questions to Ask Students During Teaching

1. **Why would a hunter-gatherer need to move?**
2. **Why would farming encourage permanent settlement?**
3. **How can surplus change society?**
4. **Why are rivers both useful and dangerous?**
5. **What can writing tell historians that a stone tool cannot?**

One-line chapter conclusion: Human history is a story of adaptation and innovation—from mobile hunter-gatherers using stone tools to settled food producers, and eventually to urban societies with specialised occupations, trade, political organisation, writing and civilisation.

Source note: Prepared from the new Class 9 NCERT framework and cross-checked against the official NCERT Grade 9 syllabus. The syllabus explicitly lists the chapter’s archaeological ages, human ancestors, hunter-gatherer life, Mesolithic transition, Neolithic revolution, Harappan and contemporary cultures, and Mesopotamian, Egyptian and Chinese civilisations. ■cite■turn2search10■